Week 6 | Algorithmic Identity: The Version of Me the Platform Sees

Reflection

This week I did something that honestly made me feel a bit uncomfortable. I went into my Instagram settings and found the "Ads and Topics" page—the place where the platform lists all the categories it thinks I belong to. It was strange. Some of it was almost right: "Film and TV," "Music," "Photography." But then there were categories I had never consciously signed up for: "Consumer Electronics," "Home and Garden," "Parenting"—parenting! I don't have children. I clicked through and realised that the platform had built a version of me that was partly accurate but also partly made up, pieced together from my likes, my scrolling, my location, and probably things my friends had liked. I tried to remove the wrong categories, but I wasn't sure if that actually changed anything. The whole experience made me realise that there is a version of me on Instagram that I didn't create and that I can't fully control. That is what Cheney-Lippold (2017) is talking about.

Cheney-Lippold argues that we have "algorithmic identities"—versions of ourselves that are produced by algorithms through categorisation. These identities are not the same as how we see ourselves, and they are not stable. They change as the algorithm learns more about us. This is exactly what I saw in my Instagram settings. The platform had classified me based on patterns in my behaviour, not based on who I actually am. And those classifications had consequences: they determined which ads I saw, which content was pushed to me, maybe even which posts were shown at the top of my feed. Cheney-Lippold's key point is that these algorithmic identities are not just descriptions; they are productive. They shape our experience and even our sense of self.

This also connects to Sumpter's (2018) chapter on how he classifies his friends. Sumpter tries to categorise his Facebook friends into groups based on their interests and online behaviour. It is a fun exercise, but it is also revealing. He acknowledges that his categories are rough and that some friends fit into multiple groups or none at all. That is the same problem I found with Instagram. The platform's categories did not capture the messiness of my actual identity. I am not just one thing. I am a student, a friend, a reader, someone who likes cooking but also someone who is not a parent. But the algorithm needs categories to make predictions, so it simplifies. Sumpter's chapter helped me see that this simplification is not a bug—it is how classification works. The problem is when the simplified version starts to be treated as the real thing.

The prompt asked what algorithmic identity means and how it connects to my own online experience. For me, it means that my identity is being constructed by platforms in ways I do not fully see or understand. That is unsettling, but it is also important to recognise. It is not just that Instagram knows things about me. It is that Instagram creates a version of me that is useful for its business model. Cheney-Lippold would say that this is a form of power. The platform does not just reflect who I am; it helps produce who I am by showing me certain content, certain ads, certain people. That is why this week's topic matters beyond just one module. Algorithmic identity is not a technical curiosity. It is a political and social issue. It affects how we understand ourselves and how others understand us.

What did this week teach me about digital methods and digital media? It taught me that identity is not something we simply express online. It is something that gets computed. As a digital media student, I need to be critical of the categories platforms assign to me and to others. I also need to think about the ethics of classification: who gets to define the categories, who is left out, and what happens when those categories are wrong.

I have added this week’s supporting materials below. I have also noticed that many of my friends intentionally perform only a partial version of themselves before algorithms. When they post or comment online, they tend to present an identity tied to one specific area of interest, rather than feeling comfortable revealing the full complexity of who they are. As a result, a person’s algorithmic identity can diverge sharply from their broader social identity.